WATER & FOOD CALCULATOR

Work out how much water and food your household should keep on hand, then plan how to store and rotate it.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General preparedness information, not a substitute for professional advice, local emergency-management instructions or manufacturer directions. Needs differ by household and location. **Verify important information with current official sources before relying on it.**

1. THE NUMBERS TO START WITH

ITEM	RECOMMENDED AMOUNT	NOTES
Water	**1 gallon per person per day**: about half for drinking, half for cooking and basic hygiene.	Keep at least 3 days' worth. If you can, keep 2 weeks at home.
Food	At least a **3-day supply** that needs no refrigeration and little or no cooking.	2 weeks at home if you can. Choose food your household already eats.
Need more water	Hot weather, nursing mothers, children, sick people, and anyone very active.	Heat can double what a person needs.
Pets	Water and food for each animal for the same number of days.	Ask your vet how much your animal drinks each day.

(!) **IN AN EMERGENCY, DRINK THE WATER YOU NEED TODAY.** Don't ration water to stretch it out; find more tomorrow. Stretch it by cutting activity and staying cool, not by drinking less.

2. WATER WORKSHEET

STEP	YOUR NUMBER	EXAMPLE (4 PEOPLE, 14 DAYS)
A. Number of people		4
B. Number of days you're planning for		14
C. Gallons per person per day (1, or more in heat)		1
D. People water: A x B x C		56 gallons
E. Pet water for the same days		7 gallons (one large dog)
TOTAL WATER TO STORE: D + E		**63 gallons**

For reference: a standard case of bottled water (24 x 16.9 oz) is about 3.2 gallons. A 7-gallon water container weighs about 58 lb when full.

3. STORING WATER

- Store-bought bottled water is the simplest. Keep it sealed and use it by the date on the package.
- If you fill your own, use food-grade containers made for water, or clean soda bottles. Don't use milk jugs (they break down and are hard to clean) or anything that held chemicals.
- Store in a cool, dark place, away from gasoline, pesticides and other chemicals.
- Keep some in sizes you can carry if you have to leave.

- Label home-filled containers with the date and **replace the water every 6 months**.
- Your water heater holds 30 to 80 gallons and is an emergency source if you know how to drain it safely. Turn off its power or gas first.
- If water might be unsafe, treat it before drinking. *(TR-02)*

4. FOOD WORKSHEET

A simple target is about **2,000 calories per adult per day**, the figure Nutrition Facts labels are based on. Very active adults and teenagers may need more; young children need less. Ask your doctor about special diets.

STEP	YOUR NUMBER	EXAMPLE
A. Adults and teens x 2,000 calories		2 x 2,000 = 4,000
B. Children x 1,400 calories (roughly; less for toddlers)		2 x 1,400 = 2,800
C. Calories per day: A + B		6,800
D. Number of days		14
TOTAL CALORIES TO STORE: C x D		**95,200**

To check your shelf: calories per serving x servings per container (both on the label) = calories per container.

5. WHAT TO STORE

GOOD CHOICES

- Canned meat, fish, beans, soups, stews, fruit and vegetables.
- Peanut butter and other nut butters; nuts and trail mix.
- Crackers, cereal, granola and protein bars, dried fruit.
- Shelf-stable milk, powdered milk, juice boxes.
- Rice, pasta and oats, if you can cook and have extra water.
- Comfort foods: coffee, tea, a few treats. They matter more than you'd think.

RULES OF THUMB

- Store what you already eat, and eat what you store: use the oldest first and replace it ("first in, first out").
- Salty foods make you thirsty. Go easy on them unless you have plenty of water.
- Keep a **manual can opener**, plus plates, cups and utensils.
- Remember infant formula, baby food, allergy-safe and medical diets, and pet food.
- Throw away cans that are swollen, leaking, rusted or badly dented.

6. WHEN THE POWER GOES OUT: FRIDGE AND FREEZER

IF THE DOOR STAYS CLOSED	FOOD STAYS SAFE FOR ABOUT
Refrigerator	**4 hours**
Full freezer	**48 hours** (24 hours if half full)

- Eat the food from the refrigerator first, then the freezer, then your stored food.
- Keep a thermometer in the fridge and freezer. Throw out perishable food (meat, fish, eggs, milk, leftovers) that has been above **40°F for 2 hours or more**.
- Never taste food to check it. **When in doubt, throw it out.**

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. FEMA: Ready.gov: Water; Food. ready.gov/water ready.gov/food
2. U.S. Food and Drug Administration: How to Understand and Use the Nutrition Facts Label. fda.gov
3. USDA / FoodSafety.gov: Food Safety During Power Outages. foodsafety.gov
4. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Creating and Storing an Emergency Water Supply. cdc.gov/water-emergency

IMPORTANT: These are planning figures, not prescriptions. Infants, older adults, pregnant or nursing women and people with medical conditions may need more water or different foods. Ask your doctor.